

KEY TOPIC 3: NAZI CONTROL AND DICTATORSHIP

Assessment Question: From Democracy to Dictatorship: How did Hitler destroy the Weimar Republic?

Name: _____

Class: _____

Progress & Assessment Tracker	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments
L1: Key Topic 3.1: The Creation of a Dictatorship, 1933–1934			
L2: Key Topic 3.2: The Police State and Religion, 1933–1939			
L3: Key Topic 3.3: Controlling and Influencing Attitudes, 1933–1939			
L4: Key Topic 3.4: Opposition, Resistance and Conformity, 1933–1939			
Final Unit Grade:			

L1: Key Topic 3.1: The Creation of a Dictatorship, 1933–1934

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate precise chronological knowledge of the rapid steps Hitler took to secure power between January 1933 and August 1934.
- ☐ Analyse how Hitler used the Reichstag Fire and the Enabling Act to legally destroy political opposition and civil liberties.
- ☐ Evaluate the significance of the Night of the Long Knives and the Army Oath in eliminating internal threats and securing absolute power as Führer.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. On what exact date did Paul von Hindenburg appoint Adolf Hitler as Chancellor of Germany?

2. What is meant by the historical term 'backstairs intrigue'?

3. How many Nazis were actually allowed in Hitler's very first Cabinet in January 1933?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about why Franz von Papen believed he could control Hitler in 1933.

Active Tasks

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q1. Complete the following sentences based on the lesson narrative:

Vocabulary in Context

Q2. Use the following five keywords in a short paragraph (3-5 sentences) that accurately describes a key step in Hitler's consolidation of power, demonstrating your understanding of their meaning and historical context: *Reichstag Fire, Emergency Decree, Enabling Act, Gleichschaltung, One-party state*.

Causal Linkage

Q3. Explain the causal chain linking the growing power of the SA under Ernst Röhm, the concerns of the German Army, and the event known as the Night of the Long Knives. Your answer should clearly articulate how each factor contributed to the next.

Counter-Factual History

Q4. Imagine that President Paul von Hindenburg had lived for another five years beyond August 1934. How might this have altered the pace and nature of Hitler's consolidation of power and the establishment of a totalitarian dictatorship? Consider at least two specific ways Hindenburg's continued presence could have impacted events.

GCSE Exam Practice

Exam Practice

1. 2. Explain why Hitler was able to consolidate his dictatorship in 1933–34 (12 marks).

You may use the following in your answer:

- The Night of the Long Knives
- The Reichstag Fire exploitation

You must also use information of your own.

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Exam Sources & Interpretations

Source B (Contemporary Written Source): From police chief Rudolf Diels' secret report on the Reichstag Fire, February 1933.

The Reichstag building was still burning when the leadership arrived. Hitler stood on the balcony, his face red from the heat, shouting uncontrollably: 'This is the signal for a Communist uprising! We will show them no mercy. Every Communist official must be arrested and shot on sight.' The list of arrests had already been prepared, and the police were put on high alert immediately.

Source C (Contemporary Written Source): From a letter written by a senior German army officer, July 1934.

We are deeply relieved that the Chancellor has crushed the leadership of the SA. Ernst Röhm's plan to absorb our regular regiments into his three-million-strong militia threatened the honor and security of the army. By taking swift, bloody action against these armed thugs, Hitler has restored discipline and earned our absolute, unconditional loyalty.

Interpretation 1 (The Legalistic Emergency View):

Hitler consolidated his dictatorship primarily by exploiting the Reichstag Fire to construct a legal state of emergency. By immediately securing the Decree for the Protection of the People and the State, the regime dismantled all constitutional civil liberties. This allowed them to legally terrorize the Communist Party, secure a parliamentary majority, and pass the Enabling Act, which permanently ended democracy.

Interpretation 2 (The Paramilitary Purge View):

The decisive turning point in the consolidation of the Nazi dictatorship was the elimination of the internal threat through the Night of the Long Knives in June 1934. By using the SS to violently execute Röhm and other SA rivals, Hitler secured the backing of the regular army and the industrial elites. The subsequent personal Oath of Allegiance sworn by the military cemented his absolute power as Führer.

2. 3a. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the creation of a dictatorship, 1933–34? (8 marks)

3. 3b. Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about the creation of a dictatorship, 1933–34. What is the main difference between these views? (4 marks)

4. 3c. Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about the creation of a dictatorship, 1933–34. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4 marks)

5. 3d. How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 about the creation of a dictatorship, 1933–34? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16 marks)

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General Notes

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- ☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L2: Key Topic 3.2: The Police State and Religion, 1933–1939

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate precise knowledge of the different, overlapping branches of the Nazi police state, distinguishing between the roles of the SS, SD, and Gestapo.
- ☐ Analyse how the Nazis completely removed the independence of the German legal system to ensure the courts always ruled in Hitler's favour.
- ☐ Evaluate the varying successes and failures of Nazi policies towards the Catholic and Protestant churches.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. What was the name of the law passed in March 1933 that effectively allowed Hitler to rule Germany as a dictator for four years?

2. What is meant by the historical term Gleichschaltung?

3. On what exact date did Hitler launch the Night of the Long Knives?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about why Hitler felt he had to murder Ernst Röhm.

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

SS (Schutzstaffel) | SD (Sicherheitsdienst) | Gestapo | Schutzhaft (Protective Custody) | The Concordat (1933) | Reich Church | Confessional Church

Your Sentence:

Active Tasks

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q1. Complete these sentences based on the lesson narrative: 1) Hitler signed the Concordat with the Catholic Church in 1933 BUT... 2) Hitler attempted to create a unified 'Reich Church' BECAUSE... 3) The Gestapo arrested many priests and pastors SO...

Vocabulary in Context

Q2. Write a short paragraph (5-7 sentences) explaining how the Nazi regime attempted to control and suppress religious institutions between 1933 and 1939. You must accurately use ALL of the following keywords: SS, SD, Gestapo, Schutzhaft, The Concordat (1933), Reich Church, Confessional Church.

Causal Linkage

Q3. Explain the chain of events that led to the formation of the Confessional Church and the subsequent Nazi response. Your explanation should clearly link each cause to its effect.

Counter-Factual History

Q4. Imagine the Nazi regime, from 1933, had chosen a policy of *immediate and complete suppression* of all religious institutions (Catholic and Protestant), rather than the historical path of initial conciliation (Concordat) and gradual subversion. Analyze the potential short-term and long-term consequences of this alternative policy for the Nazi regime's power, international standing, and public support within Germany, compared to the actual historical path.

GCSE Exam Practice

Exam Practice

1. 2. Explain why the Nazi police state was able to maintain control in Germany between 1933 and 1939 (12 marks).

You may use the following in your answer:

- **The Gestapo**
- **Block Wardens**

You must also use information of your own.

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Exam Sources & Interpretations

Source B (Contemporary Written Source): From a Gestapo arrest warrant issued in the Rhineland, July 1938.

The suspect, a 64-year-old woman, was overheard by other customers in a café remarking that Mussolini had more political sense in one of his boots than Hitler has in his brain. The Gestapo was immediately alerted by telephone, and officers arrived to arrest the suspect five minutes later. She has been detained under a protective custody warrant (Schutzhaft).

Source C (Contemporary Written Source): From the Nazi Party's official Organisation Book, detailing the role of Block Wardens.

It is the sacred duty of the local Block Warden (Blockleiter) to monitor every household in his designated building. You must listen to the daily gossip, identify any residents who spread rumors harmful to the party, or refuse to give the Hitler salute. Such individuals must be reported immediately to the local party leader so they can be turned over to the State Secret Police.

Interpretation 1 (The Totalitarian Terror View):

The Nazi regime maintained absolute control through a pervasive, terrifying, and all-powerful system of terror. The overlapping networks of the SS, the SD, and the Gestapo achieved a comprehensive penetration of daily life. By bypassing the legal system, establishing biased 'People's Courts', and placing thousands in concentration camps without trial, the police state successfully intimidated and silenced the entire population.

Interpretation 2 (The Public Cooperation View):

The image of an all-knowing Gestapo that monitored every citizen was largely a myth created by propaganda and public fear. In reality, the Gestapo was heavily understaffed and had very few officers in major cities. The system functioned only because of the voluntary cooperation of ordinary, non-party citizens. Since over 80% of political cases were initiated by unpaid public denunciations, the police state relied far more on public cooperation than on physical coercion.

2. 3a. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the nature of the Nazi police state? (8 marks)

3. 3b. Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about the nature of the Nazi police state. What is the main difference between these views? (4 marks)

4. 3c. Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about the nature of the Nazi police state. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4 marks)

5. 3d. How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 about the nature of the Nazi police state? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16 marks)

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General Notes

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☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L3: Key Topic 3.3: Controlling and Influencing Attitudes, 1933–1939

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate precise knowledge of the methods Goebbels used to censor the press, literature, and radio.
- ☐ Analyse how the Nazis utilised mass rallies, the 1936 Berlin Olympics, and cheap technology (like the Volksempfänger) as tools of indoctrination.
- ☐ Evaluate the ways in which the Nazis crushed independent thought by controlling art, architecture, and music through the Reich Chamber of Culture.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. What was the name of the government department set up in 1935 to weaken the power of Christianity?

2. What is meant by the German term Schutzhaft (Protective Custody)?

3. Who was the brutal judge placed in charge of the People's Court?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about the difference between the SS, the SD, and the Gestapo.

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **Censorship**

Active Tasks

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q1. Complete these sentences based on the lesson's narrative:

Vocabulary in Context

Q2. Using at least three of the keywords (Censorship, Propaganda, Ministry of Public Enlightenment and Propaganda, Volksempfänger, Reich Chamber of Culture, Entartete Kunst), write a short paragraph explaining how the Nazis controlled and influenced attitudes in Germany.

Causal Linkage

Q3. Explain how the Nazi regime's control over culture and media, through institutions like the Ministry of Public Enlightenment and Propaganda and the Reich Chamber of Culture, contributed to the consolidation of their power and the stability of the regime by 1939.

Q4. The 'What If' Challenge (Counter-Factual History): What if the Nazi regime had *failed* to establish effective control over radio and film in the early years (1933-1935)? How might this have significantly altered the trajectory of Nazi Germany's consolidation of power and public support by 1939?

GCSE Exam Practice

Exam Practice

1. 2. Explain why the Nazi regime was able to control and influence attitudes in Germany, 1933-1939. (12 marks)

You may use the following in your answer:

- The role of Joseph Goebbels
- The use of radio and other media

You must also use information of your own.

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Exam Sources & Interpretations

Source B (Contemporary Written Source):

From Goebbels' written instructions to Nazi party speakers, July 1935.
"The finest kind of propaganda does not reveal itself; it works invisibly, penetrating every cell of life so that the public has no idea of its goals. For Wednesday's broadcast of the Leader's speech, all factory owners, offices, and shops must install speakers. The entire workforce must be gathered to listen, and the press must discuss this decision as the only possible path for Germany."

Source C (Contemporary Written Source):

From a private letter written by an ordinary citizen in Hamburg, 1937.
"Every evening on the radio, we are subjected to the same repetitive speeches, military marches, and achievements of the state. The newspapers contain only approved Nazi articles, and we are expected to attend massive local rallies. While everyone stands and salutes to avoid trouble, behind closed doors, my family simply turns off the wireless, tired of the endless, mind-numbing propaganda."

Interpretation 1 (The Total Indoctrination View):

The Ministry of Popular Enlightenment and Propaganda was highly successful in coordinating and controlling the minds of the German population. Goebbels recognized that by establishing absolute censorship over radio, cinema, and newspapers, the regime could isolate the public from alternative views. Through constant repetition and subtle cultural coordination, they successfully Nazified public attitudes.

Interpretation 2 (The Superficial Compliance View):

The impact of Nazi propaganda was highly limited and achieved only a superficial compliance. While the regime succeeded in forcing outward displays of loyalty—such as the Hitler salute and attendance at state rallies—it failed to change deep-seated religious and political beliefs. Many Germans developed a cynical indifference to the repetitive propaganda, complying solely to protect themselves from Gestapo arrest.

2. 3a. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into controlling and influencing attitudes? (8 marks)

3. 3b. Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about controlling and influencing attitudes. What is the main difference between these views? (4 marks)

4. 3c. Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about controlling and influencing attitudes. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4 marks)

5. 3d. How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about controlling and influencing attitudes? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16 marks)

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Teacher Comment:

L4: Key Topic 3.4: Opposition, Resistance and Conformity, 1933–1939

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate precise knowledge of the different youth opposition groups, distinguishing between the working-class Edelweiss Pirates and the middle-class Swing Youth.
- ☐ Analyse the methods used by underground political networks, industrial workers, and lone-wolf attackers to resist the Nazi state.
- ☐ Evaluate the reasons why the vast majority of the German population conformed to Nazi rule rather than actively opposing it.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. What was the name of the Nazi publishing house that bought up 82% of all German newspapers by 1939?

2. What is meant by the Nazi term Entartete Kunst?

3. How many gold medals did Germany win at the 1936 Berlin Olympics?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about how Joseph Goebbels used radio to brainwash the German public.

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Conformity | Passive Resistance | Active Resistance | Sopade Reports | Sabotage | Edelweiss Pirates
| Swing Youth

While the Gestapo's reign of terror ensured widespread _____ among the adult population, the exiled SPD bravely documented pockets of dissent by smuggling out the secret _____. Some brave individuals engaged in dangerous _____, such as industrial workers deliberately carrying out _____ in armaments factories. Among teenagers, opposition took the form of social rebellion; middle-class teens embraced banned American jazz music as the _____, while working-class youths formed groups like the _____ to physically fight Hitler Youth patrols.

Active Tasks

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q1. Complete the following sentences based on the lesson narrative:

Vocabulary in Context

Q2. Write a short paragraph (approximately 100 words) explaining the different forms of opposition to the Nazi regime between 1933-1939, using at least five of the following keywords correctly: Conformity, Passive Resistance, Active Resistance, Sopade Reports, Sabotage, Edelweiss Pirates, Swing Youth.

Causal Linkage

Q3. Explain how a combination of Nazi policies and the nature of opposition led to widespread conformity rather than successful resistance in Germany between 1933 and 1939.

Counter-Factual History

Q4. Imagine a scenario where the SPD and KPD had managed to form a unified, underground resistance movement immediately after 1933, receiving significant support from the Confessional Church and trade unions. How might this have altered the nature and effectiveness of opposition to the Nazi regime by 1939, and what challenges would such a movement still have faced?

GCSE Exam Practice

Exam Practice

1. 2. Explain why there was limited widespread opposition to the Nazi regime in Germany between 1933 and 1939 (12 marks).

You may use the following in your answer:

- The effectiveness of the Nazi police state
- The appeal of Nazi policies

You must also use information of your own.

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Exam Sources & Interpretations

Source B (Contemporary Written Source): From a sermon preached by Pastor Martin Niemöller in Berlin, 1937.

Our fellow pastors are being arrested because they spoke the truth. The state-controlled Reich Church seeks to replace the Cross of Christ with the Swastika. We are told that if we remain silent, the Church will have peace. But I say to you, a silent Church is a dead Church. We must obey God rather than men, even if it leads us to the concentration camps.

Source C (Contemporary Written Source): From a secret Gestapo surveillance report on religious attitudes in Bavaria, 1937.

The influence of the Catholic Church on the rural population remains unbroken. The local population is ever under the strong influence of the priests and prefers to believe what they say from the pulpit rather than the words of our best party speakers. Direct arrests of these priests during services are restricted by the Concordat, which they exploit to spread subtle criticisms of the government.

Interpretation 1 (The Brave Resistance View):

The Christian Churches in Germany were largely successful in resisting the Nazi regime's attempts to achieve total control over religious life. Despite intense pressure, both the Catholic and Protestant Churches prevented the total Nazification of their institutions. The creation of the Confessing Church by thousands of brave pastors successfully defended theological independence, proving that religious faith remained a powerful barrier to totalitarian control.

Interpretation 2 (The Limited Conformity View):

Christian opposition to the Nazi regime was extremely limited, narrow, and ultimately failed to challenge the wider atrocities of the state. The vast majority of church leaders conformed because they shared Hitler's hatred of communism and feared the destruction of their institutions. When pastors spoke out, their protests were strictly limited to defending church administration; they remained entirely silent during the persecution of minorities and the destruction of democracy.

2. 3a. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into religious opposition to the Nazi regime? (8 marks)

3. 3b. Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about religious opposition to the Nazi regime. What is the main difference between these views? (4 marks)

4. 3c. Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about religious opposition to the Nazi regime. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4 marks)

5. 3d. How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 about religious opposition to the Nazi regime? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16 marks)

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Teacher Comment:
